



Optenet Web Filter has a browser-based interface that's very different from the others—not better, just different. It offers port blocking and can disable P2P applications and Instant Messengers

to open in IE, I had a username and password dialog pop up.

The Web interface is a little irritating, but might be easier for people less accustomed to PCs. Every option is visible on the page in the form of links, instead of behind tabs and buttons like in every other software. I personally hated it though!

The configuration options were easy enough to follow, and the “Advanced Configuration” link took me to options where I could set port blocking and P2P application blocking settings.

A disappointment was the lack of a Task Manager disabler, which made it easy to bypass the software's protection. It was good at blocking obvious pornography, but failed miserably in my Innocuous Site test!

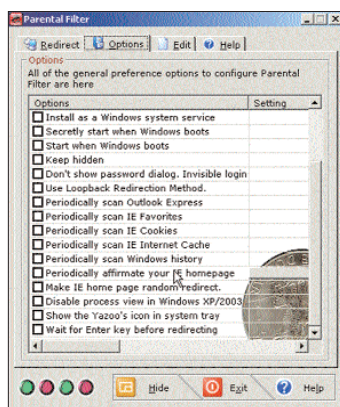
Smart Google Image searches also brought this software to its knees.

Overall, this product is just about average as a porn blocker, and has nothing too special to write home about. The best thing that can be said about it is that it offers decent port blocking and monitoring, and successfully blocks IMs and P2P applications.

Parental Filter 0.24

This is freeware from www.ecomm-sec.com, and is just a 3.03 MB download. It installs easily, but offers many advanced configuration options that might confuse not-so-tech-savvy parents. For those at home on a PC, this software offers some interesting options.

It does not offer e-mail reporting or logging, but allows you to completely hide the application and even run it as a Windows Service. You need to be careful though, because if you set the option to disable the Task Manager, and set it to hide itself, you might not be able to uninstall it too easily, or even find the administrator controls for that matter. Again, this is bad for PC novices, and good for those who know how to use it and get additional security.



If anything, Parental Filter offers you a little too much control! It's an excellent option—especially because it's completely free

The software can be set to scan your Favorites and Outlook Express, and allow you to redirect to sites of your choice when adult content is found. This is good: all the other software with this feature redirect you to their home pages, making it obvious that they're protecting your PC.

You can also tweak the way the software works depending on how much of system resources you have and how powerful your CPU is, by setting the milliseconds the software waits before re-scanning a page.

Parental Filter showed some bugs with Firefox and Opera however, most noticeably in Firefox, where instead of redirecting to the page that I set, it just kept opening new tabs. So at one point I had this porn Web site open and about 20 google.com Firefox tabs!

It was not too hard to bypass its filtering in Google Images. At one point, I clicked on a rather graphic image result. Google opens image results in frames—the top frame is by Google, and the bottom frame is the site where the image is located. The top frame was redirected to google.com (as I had set it to), while the bottom frame just went ahead and loaded!

Apart from these bugs, the software performed decently, and even caught a lot of Internet slang for pornographic content when I used them as search keywords, or when they were found on a page.

A bug in the security meant that if you do not disable the Task Manager, you can End Task the application and then uninstall it! It does not ask for the administrator password when uninstalling, unlike all the other software. However, if you disable the Task Manager via the software, it will not let you uninstall while the process is running—you have to open the administration panel using the password and stop the application before uninstalling it.

Apart from the few bugs, this is a good software that filters as decently as the other software in this test—better than quite a few, actually—and has only a few hiccups with Firefox that might be addressed with the next release. Considering that it doesn't cost you a paisa, I would recommend that everyone install this software to protect your kids. If you're willing to spend, however, that's a different story!

We-Blocker 2.0

This is another freeware tool, and the last software in our test. It's 2.41 MB large, and you can get it at www.we-blocker.com. As usual, it's easy to install and configure.

As soon as you install it, you can select the age of the child who uses the computer, and select what subjects you want to block. Pornography, adult subjects, and any categories you define are blocked by default. You have to update the We-Blocker data after installation to get the latest list of blocked sites.

The software does not offer e-mail notification, but does keep logs that you can check. It offers password protection, but does not offer Task Manager disabling. But when I End-Tasked it using the Task Manager, it